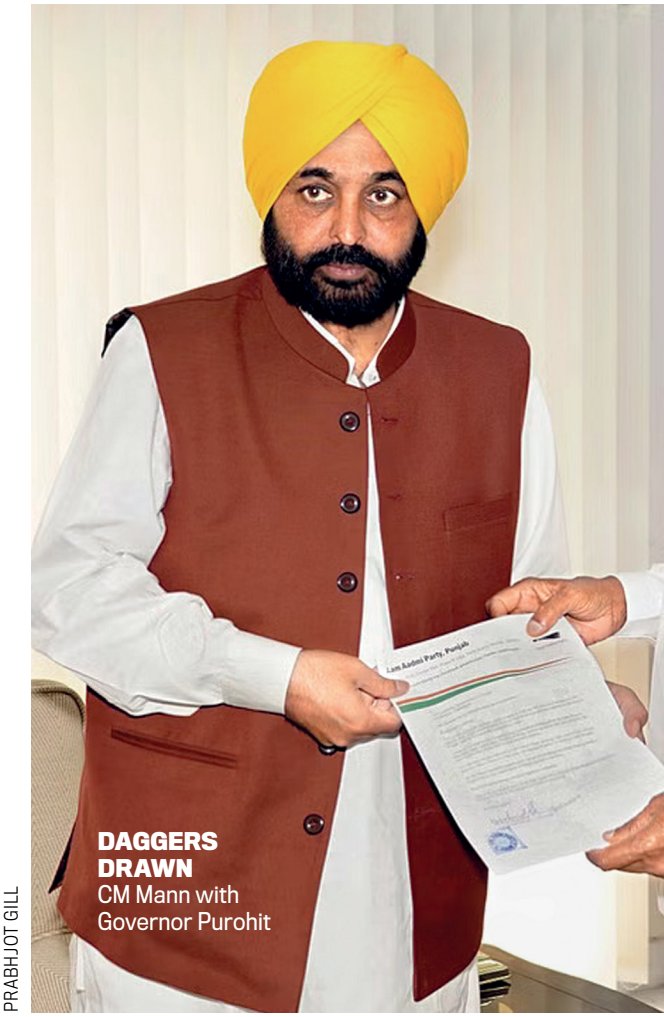
ment. Later in July, the Punjab government appointed AAP Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha as chairman of its advisory committee. The allegation is that Chadha takes the bulk of the governance decisions, though he himself denies any such thing and dismisses it as a campaign to defame the government, telling his associates, "I am the *chhota bhai* of the super-duper CM that Bhagwant Mann is and work under his able guidance and leadership." About Kejriwal running the government remotely, the AAP source says, "We fought the election on Kejriwal Ki Guarantee and people voted for us because they have seen the governance that Delhi has enjoyed and benefited from and want it replicated in Punjab." Mann has moved to implement AAP's original plank of being against corruption, though the party's national credibility has suffered a dent after its deputy chief minister in Delhi Manish Sisodia and health minister Satyendar Jain have been jailed on corruption charges and forced to resign recently.

Mann has earned praise, though, for cracking down on certain corrupt political leaders and bureaucrats. He made headlines, for instance, for dramatically sacking his own health minister Vijay Singla on corruption charges. He also had his horticulture minister Fauja Singh Sarari resign for the same reason. Meanwhile, he has gone after a dozen erstwhile Congress leaders, including Sadhu Singh Dharamsot and Bharat Bhushan Ashu, and had them arrested. AAP insiders say that Mann's action against his own ministers could very much be part of the party's political strategy to deflate the opposition's allegations of a witch-hunt against them.

As regards implementing the Delhi model, Mann is pushing to upgrade the state's school infrastructure and set up mohalla clinics—both programmes that the AAP pushes as its best work in the national capital. In the last week of January, the chief minister started an ambitious plan to upgrade 117 government schools as "schools of eminence". Unlike Delhi, the challenge here is the availability of teachers. Out of the 20,000 government schools in the state, 400 are without teachers and 1,600 schools had only one teacher. Likewise with its efforts to rapidly set up 500 'Aam Aadmi Clinics' on the lines of the 'mohalla clinics' in Delhi. Punjab's health department has not been able to find enough trained medical staff to fill these mohalla clinics. The AAP source brushes aside these observations and says, "The kind of governance and welfare activities that have happened in the past one year have not happened in the past several decades under Akali and Congress rule. Remarkable work has been done in providing healthcare, education and providing free electricity apart from a lot being done on crop diversification and agriculture."

MONEY TROUBLES

Mann's big victory in the assembly polls came on the back of a promise of dishing out freebies, some of which he has implemented (see *AAP Report Card*). The promise of free electricity of up to 300 monthly units to every household was implemented from July 1,



DAGGERS DRAWN
CM Mann with Governor Purohit

PRABHJOT GILL

a largesse that will cost the state Rs 1,800 crore annually. The power subsidy bill alone is set to cross the Rs 20,000 crore mark this fiscal year, in addition to the Rs 7,117 crore due from the previous fiscal. Another bazooka could come with the state's plans to implement the old pension scheme (OPS). Punjab will require Rs 18,000 crore for the purpose—it is pinning its hopes on refunds from the central government's Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA), but will find it difficult to secure this. The state will also incur an expenditure of Rs 6,947 crore on free farm power and Rs 2,503 crore for the subsidy to industry. The AAP government has yet to fulfil its promise of giving Rs 1,000 per month to the women of Punjab who are above 18 years of age. Count that as an additional Rs 12,000 crore per year expense for the state exchequer.

This, when the coffers are as good as empty. Mann inherited a state with a beleaguered balance sheet, with a debt-to-GDP ratio of 48.84 per cent; the Finance Commission recommends a limit of around 20 per cent. The state had Rs 2.83 lakh crore consolidated debt on its books last year, which is expected to go up to Rs 3.03 lakh crore by March-end. And this if the state sticks to the expenses and achieves the target of Rs 95,378 crore expected revenue, which seems unlikely. For the past several years, the state has fallen short of expectations